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Caustics: A Python Package for Accelerated Strong Gravitational Lensing Simulations

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Summary

Gravitational lensing is the deflection of light rays due to the gravity of intervening masses. This phenomenon is observed in a variety of scales and configurations, involving any non-uniform mass such as planets, stars, galaxies, clusters of galaxies, and even the large scale structure of the universe. Strong lensing occurs when the distortions are significant and multiple images of the background source are observed. The lens objects must align on the sky of order ~ 1 arcsecond for galaxy-galaxy lensing, or 10's of arcseonds for cluster-galaxy lensing. As the discovery of lens systems has grown to the low thousands, these systems have become pivotal for precision measurements and addressing critical questions in astrophysics. Notably, they facilitate the measurement of the Universe's expansion rate (e.g. K. C. Wong et al., 2020), dark matter (e.g. Hezaveh et al., 2016; Vegetti & Vogelsberger, 2014), supernovae (e.g. Rodney et al., 2021), quasars (e.g. Peng et al., 2006), and the first stars (e.g. Welch et al., 2022) among other topics. With future surveys expected to discover hundreds of thousands of lensing systems, the modelling and simulation of such systems must occur at orders of magnitude larger scale then ever before. Here we present `caustics`, a Python package designed to handle the extensive computational demands of modeling such a vast number of lensing systems.

Statement of need

The next generation of astronomical surveys, such as the Large Synoptic Sky Telescope survey and Euclid wide survey, are expected to uncover hundreds of thousands of gravitational lenses (Collett, 2015), dramatically increasing the scientific potential of gravitational lensing studies. Currently, analyzing a single lensing system can take several days or weeks, which will be infeasible as the number of known lenses increases by orders of magnitude. Thus, advancements such as computational acceleration via GPUs and/or algorithmic advances such as automatic differentiation are needed to reduce the analysis timescales. Machine learning will be critical to achieve the necessary speed to process these lenses, it will also be needed to meet the complexity of strong lens modelling. `caustics` is built with the future of lensing in mind, using `PyTorch` (Paszke et al., 2019) to accelerate the low level computation and enable deep learning

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algorithms which rely on automatic differentiation. Automatic differentiation also benefits classical algorithms such as Hamiltonian Monte Carlo (Betancourt, 2017). With these tools available, `caustics` will provide greater than two orders of magnitude acceleration to most standard operations, enabling previously impractical analyses at scale.

Several other simulation packages for strong gravitational lensing are already publicly available. The well established `lenstronomy` package has been in use since 2018 (Birrer et al., 2021); `GLAMER` is a C++ based code for modelling complex and large dynamic range fields (Metcalf & Petkova, 2014); `PyAutoLens` is also widely used (Nightingale et al., 2021); and GIGA-Lens is a specialized JAX (Bradbury et al., 2018) based gravitational lensing package (Gu et al., 2022); among others (Galan et al., 2021; Keeton, 2011; Kneib et al., 2011; Wagner-Carena et al., 2024). There are also several "in house" codes developed for specialized analysis which are then not publicly released (e.g. Suyu & Halkola, 2010). `Caustics` development has been primarily focused on three aspects: processing speed, user experience, and flexibility. The code is optimized to fully exploit PyTorch's capabilities, significantly enhancing processing speed. The user experience is streamlined by providing three interfaces to the code: configuration file, object-oriented, and functional, where each interface level requires more expertise but allows more capabilities. In this way, users with all levels of gravitational lensing simulation experience may effectively engage with the software. Flexibility is achieved by a determined focus on minimalism in the core functionality of `caustics`. All of these elements combine to make `Caustics` a capable lensing simulator to support machine learning applications, and classical analysis.

`Caustics` fulfills a timely need for a differentiable lensing simulator. Several other fields have already benefitted from such simulators, for example: gravitational wave analysis (Coogan et al., 2022; Edwards et al., 2023; K. W. K. Wong et al., 2023); astronomical image photometry (Stone et al., 2023); point spread function modelling (Desdoigts et al., 2023); light curves (Millon et al., 2024); and even generic optimization for scientific problems (Nikolic, 2018). `Caustics` is built on lessons from other differentiable codes, with the goal of enabling machine learning techniques in the field of strong lensing. With `caustics` it will now be possible to analyze over 100,000 lenses in a timely manner (Hezaveh et al., 2017; Perreault Levasseur et al., 2017).

Scope

`Caustics` is a gravitational lensing simulator. The purpose of the project is to streamline the simulation of strong gravitational lensing effects on the light of a background source. This includes a variety of parametric lensing profiles such as: Singular Isothermal Ellipsoid (SIE), Elliptical Power Law (EPL), Pseudo-Jaffe, Navarro-Frenk-White (NFW), and External Shear. Additionally, it offers non-parametric representations such as a gridded convergence or potential field. For the background source `caustics` provides a Sérsic light profile, as well as a pixelized light image. Users may easily extend these lens and source lists using templates provided in the documentation.

Once a lensing system has been defined, `caustics` may then perform various computational operations on the system such as raytracing through the lensing system, either forwards and backwards. Users may compute the lensing potential, convergence, deflection field, time delay field, and magnification. All of these operations may readily be performed in a multi-plane setting to account for interlopers or multiple sources. Since the code is differentiable (via PyTorch), one may easily also compute the derivatives of these quantities, such as when finding critical curves or computing the Jacobian of the lens equation. For example, one may project interlopers from multiple lensing planes to a single plane by computing the effective convergence, obtained with the trace of the Jacobian.

With these building blocks in place, one may construct fast and accurate simulators used to produce training sets for machine learning models or for inference on real-world systems.

Neural networks have become a widespread tool for amortized inference of gravitational lensing parameter (Hezaveh et al., 2017) or in the detection of gravitational lenses (Huang et al., 2021; Petrillo et al., 2017), but they require large and accurate training sets which can be created quickly with `caustics`. A demonstration of such a simulator is given in Figure 1 which also demonstrates the importance of sub-pixel sampling. This involves raytracing through the lensing mass and extracting the brightness of the background source. Further, the image then must be convolved with a PSF for extra realism. All of these operations are collected into a single simulator which users may access and use simply as a function of the relevant lensing and light source parameters. Since `caustics` is written in `PyTorch`, its simulators are differentiable, thus one can compute gradients through the forward model. This enables machine learning algorithms such as recurrent inference machines (Adam et al., 2023) and diffusion models (Adam et al., 2022).

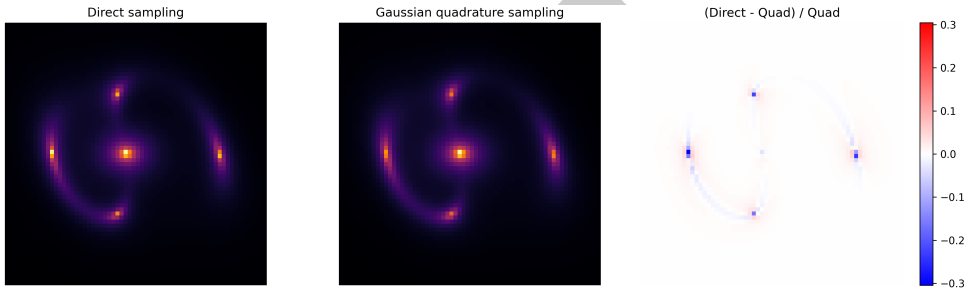

Figure 1: Example simulated gravitational lens system defined by a Sérsic source, SIE lens mass, and Sérsic lens light. Left, the pixel map is sampled only at the midpoint of each pixel. Middle, the pixel map is supersampled and then integrated using gaussian quadrature integration for greater accuracy. Right, the fractional difference between the two is shown. We can see that in this case the midpoint sampling is inaccurate by up to 30% of the pixel value in areas of high contrast. The exact inaccuracy depends greatly on the exact configuration.

The current scope of `caustics` does not include weak lensing, microlensing, or cluster scale lensing simulations. While the underlying mathematical frameworks are similar, the specific techniques commonly used in these areas are not yet implemented, though they represent an avenue for future development.

`Caustics`' defined scope ends at lensing simulation, thus it does not include functionality to optimize or sample the resulting functions. Users are encouraged to use already existing optimization and sampling codes like `scipy.optimize` (Virtanen et al., 2020), `emcee` (Foreman-Mackey et al., 2013), `dynesty` (Speagle, 2020), `Pyro` (Bingham et al., 2019), and `torch.optim` (Paszke et al., 2019).

Performance

Here we discuss the performance enhancements enabled by `caustics`. Via `PyTorch`, the code allows operations to be batched, multi-threaded on CPUs, or offloaded to GPUs to optimize computational efficiency. In Figure 2 we demonstrate this by sampling images of a Sérsic with an SIE model lensing the image (much like Figure 1). In the two subfigures we show performance for simply sampling a 128x128 image using the pixel midpoint (left), and sampling a "realistic" image (right) which is upsampled by a factor of 4 and convolved with a PSF. All parameters are randomly resampled for each simulation to avoid caching effects. This demonstrates a number of interesting facts about numerical performance in such scenarios.

We compare the performance with that of `Lenstronomy` as our baseline. The most direct comparison between the two codes can be observed by comparing the `Lenstronomy` line with the "caustics unbatched cpu" line. `Lenstronomy` is written using the `numba` (Lam et al., 2015)

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package which compiles python code into lower level C code. The left plot shows that `caustics` suffers from a significant overhead compared with `Lenstronomy`, which is nearly twice as fast as the "caustics unbatched cpu" line. This occurs because the pure Python (intepreted language) elements of `caustics` are much slower than the C/Cuda PyTorch backends (compiled language). This is most pronounced when fewer computations are needed to perform a simulation. Despite this overhead, `caustics` showcases a strong performance when using the batched GPU setting, especially in the more realistic scenario with extra computations in the simulator including 4x oversampling of the raytracing and the PSF convolution.

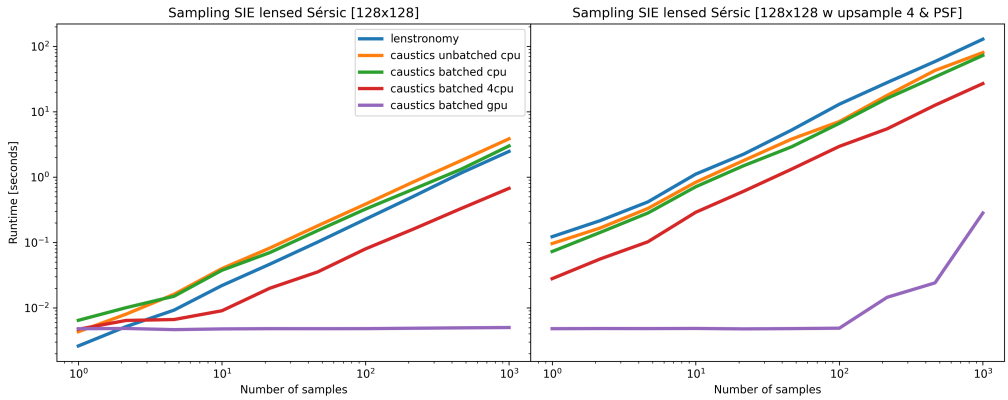

Figure 2: Runtime comparisons for a simple lensing setup. We compare the amount of time taken (y-axis) to generate a certain number of lensing realizations (x-axis) where a Sérsic model is lensed by an SIE mass distribution. For CPU calculations we use `Intel Gold 6148 Skylake` and for the GPU we use a `NVIDIA V100`, all tests were done at 64 bit precision. On the left, the lensing system is sampled 128 pixel resolution only at pixel midpoints. On the right, a more realistic simulation includes upsampled pixels and PSF convolution. From the two tests we see varying performance enhancements from compiled, unbatched, batched, multi-threaded, and GPU processing setups.

Comparing the "caustics unbatched cpu" and "caustics batched cpu" lines we see that batching can provide more efficient use of the same, single CPU, computational resources. However, in the realistic scenario the batching has minimal performance enhancement, likely because the python overhead of a for-loop is no longer significant compared to the large number of numerical operations being performed.

Comparing "caustics batched cpu" and "caustics batched 4cpu" we see that PyTorch's automatic multi-threading capabilities can indeed provide performance enhancements. However, the enhancement is not a direct multiple of the number of CPUs due to overhead. For tasks that are "embarrassingly parallel," such as running multiple MCMC chains, it is more effective to parallelize at the job level rather than at the thread level to avoid these overheads.

The most dramatic improvements are observed when comparing any CPU operations with "caustics batched gpu". Although communication between the CPU and GPU can be slow, consolidating calculations into fewer, larger batches allows caustics to fully exploit GPU capabilities. In the midpoint sampling, the GPU never "saturates" meaning that it runs equally fast for any number of samples. In the realistic scenario we reach the saturation limit of the GPU memory at 100 samples and could no longer simultaneously model all the systems, we thus entered a linear regime in runtime just like the CPU sampling does for any number of simulations. Nonetheless, it is possible to easily achieve over 100X speedup over CPU performance, making GPUs by far the most efficient method to perform large lensing computations such as running many MCMC chains or sampling many lensing realizations (e.g. for training machine learning models).

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User experience

Caustics offers a tiered interface system designed to cater to users with varying levels of expertise in gravitational lensing simulation. This section outlines the three levels of interfaces that enhance user experience by providing different degrees of complexity and flexibility.

Configuration file interface: The most accessible level of interaction is through configuration files. Users can define simulators in `.yaml` format, specifying parameters such as lens models, light source characteristics, and image processing details like PSF convolution and sub-pixel integration. The user may then load such a simulator in a single line of Python and carry on using that simulator as a pure function `f(x)` which takes in parameters such as the Sérsic index, position, SIE Einstein radius, etc. and returns an image. This interface is straightforward for new users and for simplifying the sharing of simulation configurations between users.

Object oriented interface: This intermediate level allows users to manipulate lenses and light sources as objects. The user may build simulators just like the configuration file interface, or they may interact with the objects in a number of other ways accessing further details about each lens. Each lensing object has (where meaningful) a convergence, potential, time delay, and deflection field. We provide examples to visualize all of these. Users may apply the full flexibility of Python with these lensing objects and construct customized analysis code, though there are many default routines which enable one to quickly perform typical analysis tasks.

For both the object oriented and `.yaml` interfaces, the final simulator object can be analyzed in a number of ways, Figure 3 demonstrates how one can investigate the structure of a simulator in the form of a directed acyclic graph of calculations. Note that one may also fix a subset of parameter values, making them "static" instead of the default which is "dynamic". Users can produce such a graph representation in a single line of Python for any `caustics` simulator.

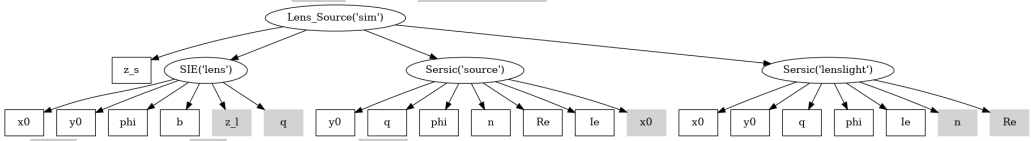

Figure 3: Example directed acyclic graph representation of the simulator from Figure 2. Ellipses are `caustics` objects and squares are parameters; open squares are dynamic parameters and greyed squares are static parameters. Parameters are passed at the top level node (`Lens_Source`) and flow down the graph automatically to all other objects which require parameter values to complete a lensing simulation.

Functional interface: The functional interface eschews the object oriented `caustics` code, instead giving the user access to individual mathematical operations related to lensing, most of which are drawn directly from gravitational lensing literature. All such functions include references in their documentation to the relevant papers and equation numbers from which they are derived. These equations have been tested and implemented in a reasonably efficient manner. This interface is ideal for researchers and developers looking to experiment with novel lensing techniques or to modify existing algorithms while leveraging robust, pre-tested components.

Each layer is in fact built on the one below it, making the transition from one to the other a matter of following documentation and code references. This makes the transition easy since one may very clearly observe how their current analysis can be reproduced in the lower level. `Caustics` thus provides a straightforward pipeline for users to move from beginner to expert. Users at all levels are encouraged to investigate the documentation as the code includes extensive docstrings for all functions, including units for most functions. This transparency not only aids in understanding and utilizing the functions correctly but also enhances the reliability and educational value of the software.

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Flexibility

The flexibility of caustics is fundamentally linked to its design philosophy, which is focused on providing a robust yet adaptable framework for gravitational lensing simulations. A focus on minimalism in the core functionality means that research-ready analysis routines must be built by the user. To facilitate this, our Jupyter notebook tutorials include examples of many typical analysis tasks, with the details laid out for the user so they may simply copy and modify to suit their particular analysis task. Thus, we achieve flexibility both by allowing many analysis paradigms, and by supporting the easy development of production code.

Research is an inherently dynamic process and gravitational lensing is an evolving field. Designing flexible codes for such environments ensures long lasting relevance. `Caustics` is well poised to grow and evolve with the needs of the community.

Machine Learning

One of the core purposes of `caustics` is to advance the application of machine learning to strong gravitational lensing analysis. This is accomplished through two avenues. First, as demonstrated in Figure 2, `caustics` efficiently generates large samples of simulated mock lensing images by leveraging GPUs. Since many machine learning algorithms are "data hungry", this translates to better performance with more examples to learn from. Literature on machine learning applications in strong gravitational lensing underscores the benefits of this generation capacity (Brehmer et al., 2019; Chianese et al., 2020; Coogan et al., 2020; Karchev, Coogan, et al., 2022; Karchev, Anau Montel, et al., 2022; Mishra-Sharma & Yang, 2022). Second, the differentiable nature of `caustics` allows it to be integrated directly into machine learning workflows. This could mean using `caustics` as part of a loss function. Alternatively, it could be through a statistical paradigm like diffusion modelling, in which `caustics` would be directly integrated in the sampling procedure. It has already been shown that differentiable lensing simulators, coupled with machine learning and diffusion modelling, can massively improve source reconstruction in strong gravitational lenses (Adam et al., 2022) and in weak lensing (Remy et al., 2023).

Conclusions

Here we have presented `caustics`, a gravitational lensing simulator framework which allows for greater than 100 times speedup over traditional CPU implementations by leveraging GPU resources. `Caustics` is fully-featured, meaning one can straightforwardly model any strong lensing system with state-of-the-art techniques. The code and documentation facilitate users transition from beginner to expert by providing three interfaces which allow increasingly more flexibility in how one wishes to model a lensing system. `Caustics` is designed to be the gravitational lensing simulator of the future and to meet the hundreds of thousands of lenses soon to be discovered with modern computational resources.

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